

BENJAMIN BLACK

Curriculum Vitæ

I am a Post-Doctoral researcher currently working within the **ValPar.CH** and **NASCENT-Peru** projects as part of the research group Planning of Landscape Urban Systems (PLUS) at ETH Zürich. Active contributor to OMF and SwissRN

EDUCATION

Oct. 2020
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Jun. 2025

Doctor of Civil Engineering

ETH Zürich, chair of Planning of Landscape Urban Systems (PLUS)
📍 Zürich, Switzerland

Thesis: Identifying effective area-based conservation strategies under uncertainties
Awards: Nominated for the ETH medal for outstanding doctoral theses

Sep. 2018
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Jun. 2020

MSc in Environmental Sciences, Policy and Management (MESPOM)

Central European University, University of Manchester, Lund University, University of the Aegean
📍 Hungary, Greece, UK

Thesis: Assessing the ecological effectiveness of protected areas in Cambodia: a quasi-experimental counterfactual estimation of avoided deforestation
Awards: Outstanding academic achievement (highest GPA in cohort: 4.00/4.00)

Sep. 2010
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Jun. 2014

BSc with 1st Class Honours in Biological Sciences

Edinburgh Napier University
📍 Edinburgh, Scotland

Thesis: Simulating the future potential of degraded Mangrove plots using field data from Kenya
Awards: University medal (highest average mark on degree route); Lawrence Ho student prize; Dennis Aw award.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

May. 2025
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Jul. 2025

Freelance Research Consultant

Prognos AG
📍 Zürich, Switzerland
Performed Land Use and Land Cover change modelling of Shared Socioeconomic Pathways for Switzerland as part of project funded by the Swiss National Centre for Climate Services

Jul. 2019
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Aug. 2019

Biodiversity and SMART Intern

The Wildlife Conservation Society (WCS)
📍 Phnom Penh, Cambodia
Developed a programmatic routine to expedite the collection of external data from the IUCN, EDGE ranking and CITES to produce protected area species inventories in line with Darwin Core standards. Assisted in the training of new community biodiversity rangers in the process of SMART data collection in the field.

Jan. 2018
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Aug. 2018

Student Affairs Manager

The School for Field Studies Center for Conservation and Development Studies in the Lower Mekong
📍 Siem Reap, Cambodia
Coordinated safety and risk management as well as logistics for all centre activities including multi day field trips to remote locations. Served as the medical point person, facilitating first aid training for staff, while also supporting student well-being and cultural adaptation in a pastoral role.



CONTACT INFO

👤 Post-Doctoral researcher
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🆔 0000-0002-8113-2114
🌐 ben-black-9889a1150
🔗 blenback
✂️ Blen_Back
🌐 <https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Benjamin-Black-5>

COMPUTER SKILLS

Advanced: R (Shiny, Quarto), Dinamica EGO and Netica
Intermediate: ArcGIS, QGIS, CSS and Git
Basic: Python and HTML

LANGUAGES

English: Native
German: B2
Khmer: Conversational

- April. 2015

June. 2017

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Project Manager & Volunteer Co-ordinator
Elephant Livelihood Initiatives and Environment (E.L.I.E)
Mondulkiri, Cambodia

Managed a diverse team (Bunong Indigenous minority, and Khmer) of 48 staff. Oversaw the operation of an ecotourism project receiving 4000+ visitors a year. Facilitated ongoing capacity building of staff and development of the volunteer program. Compiled budgets, managed cash flow, and created detailed financial and organizational reports.
- Oct. 2015

Dec. 2015

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Independent Consultant Srae Y Community ecotourism project
World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF)
Mondulkiri, Cambodia

Undertook site visits to assess the status of the project and prepared a report, detailing strategies to make the project operational and sustainable. Planned and delivered a series of training sessions to project staff and stakeholders from other communities engaged in ecotourism.
- May 2013

Apr. 2015

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Volunteer Development Officer & Conservation Support Assistant
The Conservation Volunteers (TCV)
Central Scotland

Planned, developed and delivered the Ochils Landscape Partnerships volunteering program and two TCV community health projects. Engaged with, and ensured the safety and wellbeing of a diverse cross section of volunteers, many with physical or mental disabilities as well as young adults/children.

TEACHING, TRAINING & WORKSHOP DELIVERY

- Feb. 2021

Jul. 2024

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Participatory Environmental Modelling: MSc course at ETH Zürich
Designed and taught an MSc-level course integrating students and practitioners to develop simulation models for real-world environmental decision-making.
Zürich, Switzerland
- Sep. 2024

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Reproducible Research with R and Quarto: Workflows for data, projects and publications
Three hour workshop as part of Landscape 2024 conference
Berlin, Germany

Website

GRANTS & FUNDING

- Dec. 2024

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- Jun. 2023

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NAture-positive SCenarios for ENvironmental Transitions: Peru (NASCENT-PERU)
Swiss Re Foundation
Zürich, Switzerland
Funded project under the SwissRE Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services Scenarios Modelling Initiative

Website

PUBLICATIONS

- In Review

●

Identifying robust conservation strategies to secure ecosystem service provision under uncertainties
Black, B., Adde, A., Külling, N., Büth, C., Kurmann, M., Lehmann, A., Altermatt, F., Guisan, A., Gret-Regamey, A.
Global Environmental Change
- In Review

●

Temporal Archetypes of Nature's Contributions to People for Sustainable Landscape Development
Wicki, S., Black, B., Külling, N., Kurmann, M., Wang, J., Lehmann, A., Gret-Regamey, A.
Regional Environmental Change

In Review

● **Where will the change come from? Identifying decision-relevant factors in future Land Use and Cover Change ({LUCC}) scenarios to support planning under uncertainty**

Roman, O., Adey, B., [Black, B.](#), Zeindl, E.

Futures

2024

● **Broadening the horizon in land use change modelling: Normative scenarios for nature positive futures in Switzerland**

[Black, B.](#), Adde, A., Farinotti, D., Guisan, A., Külling, N., Kurmann, M., Martin, C., Mayer, P., Rabe, S., Streit, J., Zekollari, H., Grêt-Regamey, A.

Regional Environmental Change

 Read  Data  Code

2023

● **Archetypes of social-ecological-technological systems for managing ecological infrastructure**

Wicki, S., [Black, B.](#), Kurmann, M., Grêt-Regamey, A.

Environmental Research Letters

 Read

2023

● **Re-considering the status quo: Improving calibration of land use change models through validation of transition potential predictions**

[Black, B.](#), van Strien, M. J., Adde, A., Grêt-Regamey, A.

Environmental Modelling & Software

 Read  Code

2022

● **Counterfactual assessment of protected area avoided deforestation in Cambodia: Trends in effectiveness, spillover effects and the influence of establishment date**

[Black, B.](#), Anthony, B. P.

Global Ecology and Conservation

 Read  Data



PRESENTATIONS

Jun. 2025

● **A “Scope, Simulation and Story” approach to identify future spatial development scenarios**

Computational Urban Planning and Urban Management Conference 2025

 University College London

 Slides

Sep. 2024

● **Negotiating scenarios of a desirable ecological infrastructure for Switzerland**

4th Swiss Landscape Congress

 Tramelan, Switzerland

 Slides

Jun. 2024

● **Normative scenarios of landscape change for Nature-Positive futures in Peru**

World Biodiversity Forum

 Davos, Switzerland

 Slides

Nov. 2023

● **Broadening the scope of future visions for nature positive futures in Peru**

Swiss Re Institute Resilience Summit 2023

 Zürich, Switzerland

 Slides

Sep. 2022

● **Characterising non-stationarity in predictive models of land use in Swiss mountain parks to inform scenarios for deliberative transformation**

International Mountain conference 2022

 Innsbruck, Austria

 Slides

Jul. 2022

● **ValPar.CH: Integrating land use change, Ecosystem Service and Biodiversity modelling to simulate pathways for a functioning Ecological Infrastructure for Switzerland**

11th International Environmental Modelling and Software Society conference

 Brussels, Belgium

 Slides

Jul. 2022

● **Combining filter and embedded approaches to improve variable selection in land use change Cellular Automata models**

11th International Environmental Modelling and Software Society conference

 Brussels, Belgium

 Slides

Jun. 2019

● **Ex-ante identification of policy interventions to secure a functioning ecological infrastructure: A participatory Bayesian Network approach in Switzerland**

3rd Ecosystem Services Partnership Europe Regional conference

📍 Tartu, Estonia

 Slides